

Recognizing and Helping Perfectionists

Working with Gifted Students
A Guide for Teachers and Parents



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What is Perfectionism?

Perfectionism is the tendency for a student to strive for excellence in their work. A student who demonstrates perfectionist behavior will spend extraordinary amounts of time fussing over details, learning more and more about the task at hand, and reviewing and refining the final product. For a perfectionist, a project is never complete; they simply stop working on it. Perfectionists, especially Individuals with Gifts and Talents (**IWGT**) who show perfectionist tendencies, always strive to improve. While this may sound like an admirable characteristic in a student, left unchecked and unmonitored it can have devastating effects. This negative perfectionism is called **Neurotic Perfectionism**. [6]

How does it damage a student?

Naturally, fixing mistakes requires students to examine their mistakes with a critical eye. This is how we learn, but for the Neurotic Perfectionist, they may define their work, and by extension themselves, by their mistakes. While the drive to improve in a student can be beneficial, in a gifted student the tendency becomes amplified to the point of Neuroticism [6].

A Neurotic Perfectionist may only look for ways they messed up, and this can have detrimental effects on self-esteem and perception of ability. For **IWGT**, this may also be an obstacle to learning since the goal of education shifts from trying to succeed and improving one's self towards avoiding failure [3]. True growth and learning only occurs when a student engages with material that challenges them, and the fear of failure may prevent a gifted student from pursuing new challenges, instead preferring to stay in their comfort zone [3]. Any natural curiosity or ability they have will atrophy, and their self-esteem will plummet. Gifted students already tend to struggle with feelings of isolation and depression, and **Neurotic Perfectionism** exacerbates these issues even further.

What does it look like?

Gifted students can manifest Neurotic Perfectionism in multiple ways [6]. They may:

1. Have panic attacks when faced with rapidly approaching deadlines
2. Show symptoms of anxiety
3. Have trouble starting large projects when faced with the prospect that they may fail
4. Choose to not engage in new activities and lose interest in old activities
5. Lash out or belittle peers in an effort to bolster their own feelings about themselves
6. Falter or even stagnate in emotional and social development

Pressure from Parents

When parents of **IWGT** learn of their child's gifts, they may wish to assist by pushing them to try many different avenues or capabilities. They may put a greater emphasis on grades as an objective and measurable signifier of progress and achievement [3]. This added pressure to perform wreaks havoc on a child's developing sense of autonomy and agency. It also creates anxiety associated with failure and frames education as an obstacle to overcome instead of a way to explore and improve [3].

Self-Imposed Pressure

On top of pressure from parents or other adults in their life, students may internalize a constant critical and damaging psyche [2]. This will manifest as a persistent view of their efforts and creations as inadequate and worthless [2]. Once developed, this habit is incredibly difficult to break and requires intervention. The student may seek help for the problem, but more importantly teachers, parents, and counselors must recognize these traits and work to counteract them.

Tips for Parents: From Susan T. Berry Ph.D. [1]

- Encourage open and honest dialogue about plans for the future
 - **Why?** Gifted students need practice setting realistic and attainable goals.
 - **How?** Ask your child to explain what goals they have for next year, and the year after that. Follow up until you're five years out. Then collaboratively plan ways to achieve that goal.
- Encourage your child to experience failure
 - **Why?** Gifted students need practice reflecting on mistakes in a constructive manner.
 - **How?** Take on a task or hobby together. Try to learn it with them, and ask them for help. When you make mistakes, talk about them with your child.
- Focus on enjoying time together
 - **Why?** Enjoyment of work encourages greater improvement and meaningful emotional development. It builds emotional resilience, a potential weak point for **IWGT**.
 - **How?** When you spend time together, make it a point of telling your child that you enjoyed spending time with them. Focus on the time spent completing the task, *not the outcome*.

Tips for Teachers: From the National Association for Gifted Students [5]

- Avoid Black & White descriptors and language
 - **Why?** A student with perfectionist tendencies will latch onto these extreme statements, and will likely focus heavily on the negative factors.
 - **How?** Ask questions that require students to explain decisions they made for assignments. This will foster reflection and critical thinking without focusing on negativity.
- De-emphasize grades
 - **Why?** Similar to Black & White statements, students will latch onto grades and see low grades as harmful. This can erode morale.
 - **How?** On small formative assignments, do not write a grade. Instead, provide feedback as comments. Praise, Question, Polish (PQP) is both quick and gives students constructive information to work with.
- Discuss times you have made mistakes
 - **Why?** You show students that it's okay to make mistakes as long as they reflect and improve. By modelling this behavior, you will teach students through emulation.
 - **How?** Find old examples of work and review it as a class. Ask for help editing and revising. Even if there are not major mistakes, point out the ones you catch and explain how you would fix it. You are modeling the resilience needed to fix mistakes, and that asking for help is beneficial.

References

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